

Istanbul Bariatric Center NEWSLETTER

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CALMING DOWN SELF-CRITICISM



You may have heard the saying "You are what you eat," but how about this one: "You are what you think." How much do your thoughts, feelings, and judgments affect your actions and overall well-being? In a word, a lot. Mindfulness is a practice that is becoming more popular because it helps us be aware and accepting of the present moment.

By being in the moment, we can focus on what we are doing, instead of blaming ourselves for past errors, regrets, and negative emotions. And when we start to judge ourselves, which is normal, a short mindfulness exercise can help us stop it.

Here are two mindfulness exercises to help us be in the moment and appreciate and be thankful for the good things we have.

Mindful eating

- 1. Eat at a table with no distractions.** Yes, turn off the TV and put away your smartphone or tablet. Look at the time when you start eating your meal. Take a bite of food, and chew 20 to 30 times before swallowing.
- 2. Put down your fork between bites.** Enjoy the taste and the texture: Is it savory, sweet, sour, or salty? Do this again until your plate is half full. Look at the time again. Has it been 10 to 15 minutes? If not, slow down and wait.
- 3. Talk to someone or take a few deep breaths.** Try to eat your whole meal in 30 minutes. Clear off the kitchen table and put flowers, nice placements, and maybe even candles on it to remind you that mealtime is supposed to be both fun and relaxing.



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Gratitude

1. Send more letters by mail. Write a thank-you card and mail it to your walking buddy. Set aside some time every week to write appreciation notes for your work colleagues.
2. Keep a daily personal journal. Write down the best thing that happened to you each day. Being grateful for the people in our lives can help us be kinder to ourselves. Start creating positive thoughts, and see how they grow!

Mindful eating is a practice that involves paying attention to what you eat, how you eat, and how you feel before, during, and after eating. Mindful eating can help you enjoy your food more, eat less, and improve your health and well-being. Here are some tips on how to practice mindful eating:

- **Eat with intention and attention.** Choose foods that nourish your body and mind, and eat them with awareness and appreciation. Notice the colors, smells, textures, flavors, and sounds of your food. Avoid distractions like TV, phone, or computer while eating.
- **Eat slowly and savor every bite.** Chew your food well and put down your utensils between bites. This will help you digest your food better and feel more satisfied. It will also give your brain time to register when you are full and prevent overeating.
- **Eat with gratitude and compassion.** Be thankful for the food you have and the people who prepared it. Be kind to yourself and your body, and avoid judging yourself or your food choices. Recognize that eating is a natural and pleasurable activity that supports your life and health.

